

Chapter 76-4

//

Afterward, Sheng Linlang gently told Xu Qingzhu about what happened more than twenty years ago, interspersed with her experiences with Sheng Qinglin.

Throughout Xu Qingzhu's upbringing, Sheng Linlang rarely mentioned Sheng Qinglin, as if deliberately avoiding the topic in front of her.

But occasionally she would say to Xu Qingya: "You have a very amazing uncle."

So when Xu Qingya was in kindergarten, she would brag to others about how amazing her uncle was.

Xu Qingzhu had limited experiences at school; most of the time she stayed at home, and she hadn't heard Sheng Linlang talk much about her uncle.

Thinking about it now, it was probably because Sheng Linlang didn't want her to know too much.

The Sheng siblings had contrasting personalities—one tough, one gentle.

Sheng Linlang had been gentle and quiet since childhood, with a soft temperament and easy to talk to. Sheng Qinglin, on the other hand, was stubborn with a touch of an artist's pride. He skipped grades and was soon in the same class as his older sister.

The two had a very close relationship. At school, anyone who wanted to pursue Sheng Linlang had to get past Sheng Qinglin first.

Even after all these years, when Sheng Linlang mentioned Sheng Qinglin, she said that back in their school days, he was quite the troublemaker who often gathered friends together and invited people to drink. No matter how much Sheng Linlang tried to advise him, he wouldn't listen.

But then he went to university and became devoted to academics.

Sheng Qinglin loved architectural design and had extremely high talent in this field.

Compared to him, Sheng Linlang seemed to only have beauty as her advantage.

Sheng Qinglin met Su Yao in university. The two fell in love at first sight and quickly entered a passionate relationship.

After they started dating, Sheng Qinglin often brought Su Yao to meet Sheng Linlang, so Sheng Linlang and Su Yao also knew each other and had a good relationship.

Before they even graduated, Sheng Qinglin had already brought Su Yao home several times.

When the two were about to go abroad to study, Grandmother Sheng gave Su Yao an heirloom bracelet, saying it was for her future daughter-in-law.

When Sheng Linlang saw Sheng Qinglin off at the airport, she cried so hard she could barely breathe. Sheng Qinglin said: "If you keep crying like this, I won't leave."

It was Su Yao who comforted Sheng Linlang, saying that after they left, she would take good care of Sheng Qinglin. She would also text Sheng Linlang and would definitely supervise Sheng Qinglin to study hard and achieve something.

Sheng Linlang said: "I just hope he stays safe and sound."

Su Yao said confidently: "He definitely will."

While abroad, Su Yao unexpectedly became pregnant. They originally wanted to hold the wedding while her belly wasn't showing yet, but it happened to coincide with Sheng Qinglin participating in an important engineering design project. Su Yao said it wouldn't be too late to hold the wedding after the baby was born.

During Su Yao's pregnancy, she would call Sheng Linlang every day for more than half an hour, chatting about everyday things and life back home.

But no one expected the accident to come so suddenly.

The night before Sheng Qinglin's proposal, he was still asking Sheng Linlang how exactly he should kneel on one knee to look both handsome and special.

Sheng Linlang teased him, saying he was already a father but still acting like a young kid.

Sheng Qinglin then said proudly: "My daughter is especially beautiful. I'm planning to name her Su Qingzhu, with Yaoyao's surname."

"Will Mom and Dad agree?" Sheng Linlang was somewhat worried.

The Sheng parents were rather traditional and would think it better for the child to take the Alpha's surname.

"Can't I just register my little Zhuzi's household registration¹ when we get back?" Sheng Qinglin said smugly. "When have Mom and Dad ever been able to control me?"

Sheng Linlang laughed in spite of herself. "That's true."

Sheng Qinglin also asked her if she was seeing anyone. If she was, she had to tell him immediately and bring the person for him to vet. Sheng Qinglin had even listed early on which young masters from prestigious families had bad character or bad personalities—he had basically gone through all the suitable matches².

At that time, there were indeed many people pursuing Sheng Linlang—young masters from prestigious families, talented young men, including no shortage of Alphas from noble households. But Sheng Linlang was rather fond of Xu Guangyao.

He was sincere and attentive to details, treating her well because he genuinely liked her.

Unlike those young masters from prestigious families who only wanted to pursue her to show off.

So Sheng Linlang said there was someone she was getting to know, but the relationship wasn't confirmed yet.

Sheng Qinglin immediately became anxious and said he wanted to return to China. Once Su Yao recovered, they would bring little Zhuzi back home.

Sheng Linlang teased him, saying there was no rush. After that, Sheng Qinglin would chat with her for ages, and the topic would often drift to his newborn daughter. His tone was full of pride and doting affection.

But no one expected that the next day, Sheng Qinglin got into a car accident on his way to propose to Su Yao. He didn't even make it to the hospital before he stopped breathing.

When the Sheng family found out, they immediately took a helicopter to rush there.

The Su Yao that Sheng Linlang saw then was withered and haggard, as if all the life had been drained from her. But with her just-one-month-old daughter in her arms, tears constantly streaming down her face, crying until her voice was hoarse and she couldn't control herself, she was still soothing her daughter, telling her not to cry.

The events of that day would always return as nightmares.

The Sheng parents, who had always been domineering, took Su Yao's daughter without any discussion and brought her back to China. Sheng Linlang promised Su Yao: "I will definitely bring your daughter back to you."

Because no one in the Sheng family could take care of a child.

Mother Sheng had been ill for years, and this time, because of what happened to Sheng Qinglin, she suddenly had a major breakdown. After returning from abroad, she was bedridden. Father Sheng hired a maternity nurse³ and nannies specifically to take care of the child. During the day, Sheng Linlang ran around everywhere; at night, she hid under her blanket and cried.

Sheng Linlang said: "I tried to persuade them, I begged them. I wanted Father to return you to Su Yao, but Father said no. Su Yao had gone mad, and a madwoman couldn't raise you properly."

"I later went to secretly see Su Yao. She indeed... wasn't in a good mental state." Sheng Linlang said: "I told Father I was willing to raise you together with Su Yao, but Father wouldn't allow it. He had always had extremely high expectations for Qinglin. Qinglin's death dealt him a huge blow, so he made me get married."

Sheng Linlang had always kept a low profile and rarely went out, so under her father's orders, she hastily got married. Before she could even enjoy newlywed life, she was already raising a child. At first, she truly felt extremely overwhelmed.

And Xu Qingzhu looked so much like Sheng Qinglin. At night, after Xu Qingzhu fell asleep, Sheng Linlang would watch her and cry.

When it came time to register the child's household registration and discuss the surname, Xu Guangyao naturally wanted her to take the surname Sheng. After all, she wasn't his own child, and he had no emotional attachment.

But Mother Sheng said firmly: "She'll take the surname Xu."

She told Xu Guangyao: "Raise her as your own child. Treat her well, and treat Linlang well too."

For a long time, Sheng Linlang didn't understand what her mother meant back then. After all, Xu Guangyao marrying her was considered marrying up⁴.

But later, after she became a mother herself, she understood. At that time, Mother Sheng wanted to protect both her daughter and her granddaughter. So she was willing to give up the "Sheng" surname, just wanting them to live better.

With the surname "Xu," she would be Xu Guangyao's daughter.

Sheng Linlang was never as brave as her younger brother. She didn't dare defy her parents, nor did she dare do too much.

The only thing she could do was raise her brother's child well. For this, she had even secretly had an abortion. It was only after Xu Qingzhu was a bit older that she had Xu Qingya.

Sheng Linlang said: "The person I've wronged most in my life is Su Yao."

She had once been so close to Su Yao, and had promised in front of her brother's body that she would return her daughter to her. But she couldn't keep that promise.

Later, after the Sheng parents passed away and Xu Qingzhu was a bit older, she also took Xu Qingzhu abroad.

Xu Qingzhu probably didn't remember, but at that time, Su Yao had already been sent to a psychiatric hospital for treatment. She had forgotten who Sheng Linlang was and didn't remember that she and Sheng Qinglin had even had a daughter.

Sheng Linlang was afraid of triggering her, so she brought Xu Qingzhu back.

For many years after that, they didn't contact each other again.

But guilt had always haunted Sheng Linlang, so she began to devote herself to Buddhism, trying to alleviate the pain that had built up inside her.

This was the first time Xu Qingzhu had heard anything about Sheng Qinglin—heard about his past, heard about his personality, heard about... his love for his daughter.

By the end, her eyes had turned red.

1. 上戶口 (shàng hù kǒu) - Registering a child in the household registration system (hukou) is an essential legal process in China. It determines the child's legal identity, citizenship, and access to public services. The surname given at registration becomes the child's legal surname. ⇐
2. 門當戶對 (mén dāng hù duì) - A traditional Chinese concept meaning "matching doors and windows," referring to marriages between families of equal social and economic standing. It was considered ideal for families to arrange marriages within similar social classes. ⇐
3. 月嫂 (yuè sǎo) - A specialized postpartum care provider in Chinese culture who helps new mothers and babies during the first month after birth. They assist with newborn care, breastfeeding, postpartum recovery meals, and other needs during this crucial period. ⇐
4. 高娶 (gāo qǔ) - "Marrying up" refers to marrying into a family of higher social or economic status. In this context, Xu Guangyao marrying into the prestigious Sheng family was considered advantageous for him. ⇐